chain of cause and effect went back even further: to 1948, and or even earlier.

The proximate cause, though, was indisputably the kidnappings and the Israeli crackdown that followed, dubbed “Operation Brother’s Keeper”. Virtually the entire Hamas leadership in the West Bank were among the hundreds of Palestinians arrested during nightly raids. So were fifty-eight prisoners released in the 2011 agreement to free Gilad Shalit, the Israeli soldier captured by Hamas in 2006. The campaign sent the Hamas leadership in Gaza into a panic. The officials I spoke with in mid-June figured they were next. It wasn’t an unreasonable fear. Israel had assassinated the group’s leaders in Gaza before; one such airstrike in 2012 touched off the second Israel-Hamas war.

Despite its ideology, Hamas can be a very pragmatic actor when it wants to be. The group has tight control over its own cadres, and usually works aggressively to stop other militant groups from firing rockets at Israel; perpetrators are quickly arrested and jailed. But as the Israeli operation dragged on—six Palestinians were killed during clashes and raids—the Hamas leadership went into hiding, and their security forces stopped enforcing the ban on launches. Sixty-five rockets and mortars were fired in June, up from just seven in May.

Israel responded with ever-larger rounds of airstrikes. On the evening of 29 June, one of them killed a Hamas militant. The group fired back with a barrage of rockets, its first since the ceasefire that ended the previous war, in 2012. A week later, as the back-and-forth continued, Israel bombed the house of a Hamas official in the southern city of Khan Younis, killing seven people. The group dubbed it a “massacre”. From there, things escalated quickly to a full-blown war. On 8 July Israel launched what it called (in English) “Operation Protective Edge”, a conflict that would eventually kill more than 2,000 Palestinians, the majority of them civilians. (In Hebrew it was *Tzuk Eitan*, “Firm Cliff”.)

At the time, it all seemed bewildering and abrupt. (I was eating dinner with mourners at Abu Khdair’s wake in Shuafat when it started—still reporting the last story.) In hindsight, though, it was inevitable. Lies and miscalculations: the former, Israel’s insistence on pretending that the kidnapped teenagers were still alive; the latter, the misguided belief that a massive clampdown on Hamas would pass without further consequences. As J. J. Goldberg wrote a few days later in *The Forward*, “the [kidnapping